

— General Questions —

Question 1 On a scale of 1–5, how much do you consider yourself a "gamer"? (1 = I only play to pass time, 5 = Gaming is my main hobby).

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Question 2 Which platform do you spend the most time gaming on? (PC, Console, Mobile, or Handheld like Switch/Steam Deck)

PC

Question 3 How often do you play games on your phone? (Daily, a few times a week, or rarely)

A few times a week

Question 4 Do you prefer playing games in short bursts (2–5 minutes) or long sessions (30+ minutes)?

Very long sessions (60+minutes)

Question 5 In other mobile games, do you typically make in-game purchases, watch ads for rewards, or prefer completely free-to-play experiences?

Free-to-play player

Question 6 What are your top three favorite types of games (e.g., Idle, Simulation, RPG, Puzzle)?

Strategy Games, RPG, Shooters

Question 7 What model of phone or tablet are you using for this playtest (e.g., iPhone 15, Samsung Galaxy S24)

Samsung Galaxy A52

Persona



Illia, 21 rokov

Illia je študent, ktorý vo voľnom čase občas hrá hry prevažne na PC, výnimočne aj na mobile (Samsung Galaxy A52). Herné session mu zvyknú trvať dlhšie (60+ minút), keď už hrá, ale rozhodne to nie je jeho jediná záľuba.

Má rád filmy s hĺbkou a atmosférou. Obľúbené sú The Pianist, Parasite, The Intouchables, Django Unchained a Interstellar. Zo seriálov ho zaujali Breaking Bad, Game of Thrones, Avatar: The Last Airbender a Chernobyl, teda príbehy, ktoré majú čo povedať.

Medzi jeho obľúbené hry patria Kenshi, Crusader Kings 3, RimWorld, The Witcher 3, GTA V, No Man's Sky a Counter-Strike 2. Z toho je jasné, že ho baví sloboda, objavovanie a komplexné systémy, ale vie si nájsť čas aj na rýchlejší, akčnejší zážitok. Na mobile hrá len príležitostne, niekoľkokrát týždenne, a preferuje čisto free-to-play zážitok bez nákupov alebo reklám.

Podľa Bartlovej taxonómie je primárne Explorer - baví ho skúmať mechaniky, objavovať a experimentovať. Čiastočne aj Achiever, keď mu ide o postup a plnenie cieľov. Súťaživosť ho neláka.

Illia nikdy nevytváral komplexné hry, ale herný dizajn ho zaujíma a v rámci štúdia mal skúsenosť s tvorbou jednoduchých hier. Vďaka tomu dokáže poskytovať konkrétnu a užitočnú spätnú väzbu, a to nielen ako hráč, ale aj ako niekto, kto rozumie základom dizajnu.

3. Gears Digger - Questions

Question 1 What are you supposed to do in Gear Digger? Explain it with a sentence or two.

The core gameplay involves progressing through levels using workers and other tools (sometimes potions) by integrating them into a construction-based system alongside gears of various levels. Progressing through the levels is achieved by excavating different layers: earth, stone, gold, toxic substances, layers containing components (after which you can modify the device architecture), and a fully metallic layer with a metal structure.

Question 2 How did you feel about the tutorial? Did it clearly explain how to play? If not, what felt unclear or boring?

The tutorial was very clear. Along with the game's fairly intuitive mechanics, I really liked the tutorial that explains the basics

Question 3 What did you enjoy the most? What made you want to keep playing?

I wouldn't exactly call myself a fan of these kinds of games, but overall it was interesting, and I enjoyed playing through the levels and the fact that I really had to plan my moves ahead sometimes. After all, I had to keep track of all the device layouts, my money, and the moment when I'd clear a layer, after which I could buy something, swap items, or sell them. Even though some levels felt a bit drawn out to me, it's a game you can play in your spare time.

Question 4 On a scale of 1-10, how likely are you to recommend this game to a friend? Why or why not?

6/10. It's a fun game, but I think it might get boring after a couple of hours, and the amount of ads could really put you off. The concept itself is really interesting tho, it just might bore you over time.

Question 5 Would you come back to play again later? If not, what's stopping you?

I guess I'll try to beat the game, but i'm not sure. Ads really are annoying

Question 6 If you had to change one key gameplay element to make this game more enjoyable or engaging, what would it be and how would you do it?

I'm not really sure. On the one hand, it might be interesting to merge not only cogs but also certain units. For example, merging the Builder and the Bee Drill to create a unit with mixed stats - high damage per hit like the Bee, but a lower cooldown like the Builder. On the other hand, this would require rethinking and slightly adjusting the game's logic and balance.

Question 7 Which level did you start to feel like you are getting bored of the game; and what do you think the reason is?

The second location, the second level. I think the reason is that the levels are getting longer. With the ads, it took about 8–9 minutes to complete the level, even in the second location.

Question 8 Did you find the ads overwhelming? If yes, what would you change?

Absolutely. I understand the need for ads in mobile games, but I would remove ads in the middle of levels, because they completely kill the desire to play. As a result, player engagement decreases. In other words, I would keep optional ads (boosts, extra coins during levels, etc.), and of the forced ads, I would only keep those that appear between levels.

Question 9 If you can add one rewarded ad that could benefit you in-game, what would that be? Why?

I couldn't think of anything. It seems like all the optional in-game ads have already been added.

Question 10 What do you enjoy most during the levels? (worker animations, destroying floors, strategizing your gear, bursting bubbles) Please explain your answer

100% It's the strategy element. It's really cool that in a game like this, which seems simple, you still have to think ahead instead of just clicking. The animations and sounds (including the music) are also really nice.

Question 11 How much do you feel the sense of progress when you upgrade your workers, tools, and potions? Rate it on a scale of 1–10.

I'd give it a 7. The gameplay is built around a flat power curve. This forces you to level up your units as the levels get harder, but you don't really feel like you've gotten "stronger." Still, within this concept, it's a suitable difficulty structure.

Question 12 In your opinion, what is the best gear in the game? Why?

I think it's the Excavation Wheel. Dealing percentage-based damage to a layer is very powerful, but it's balanced because it's located right next to the platform, so if you miss the moment and don't press Jump, you could lose a heart.

Question 13 How much do you feel the sense of progress when you forge and equip items?

I didn't really notice any increase in strength when equipping items, but I think that's how it should be, since they aren't supposed to have a huge impact on the game

Question 14 How would you improve the inventory system? What would you change, add, or remove? Please explain at which levels you used the inventory system the most.

I wouldn't say I used it much. I just crafted items whenever I had the chance and equipped the best ones I had.

Question 15 Which stage do you enjoy the most? Why?

I didn't really notice much of a difference between the stages. Maybe the gameplay gets more challenging. Visually, I liked the second stage the best. If each stage makes the game harder, then that confirms my choice. I haven't played the other stages besides the first and second ones.

Question 16 Which level do you think is the most challenging? Explain why and what you do to try to succeed in this level.

As I mentioned in my answers to other questions, the game generally gets harder with each level, so it's hard to single out any one specific one. But I first noticed this on the final level of the first location, and I really had to think about how to position my units and cogs

Question 17 Which IAP offer would you be most likely to purchase, and why?

x2 Speed Up or Starter Pack. The first significantly speeds up the game, while the second is because of the interest in the Robot as a unit

Question 18 Did you use the buffs before starting the level? What was your strategy for choosing them?

No, I haven't used it at all.

Question 19 What strategy did you use to decide which gear to buy during gameplay?

Typically, the best strategy was to purchase a cog that eventually generates 3,500 coins (ore), which can then be used to plan a successful and efficient layout.

Question 20 How often do you visit and buy from the in-game shop? What did you buy?

Very rarely. But I can usually buy some kind of customization.

Question 21 If you could create and add a feature to the game that would make it much more enjoyable, what would it be?

Merging units. This would expand strategy and planning, since you get units randomly, and in theory, this could really be used to increase the strategic depth at various levels.